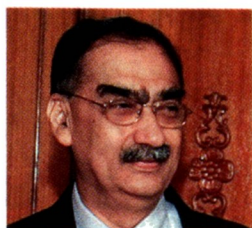




**S.M KRISHNA
(CENTRE)
INAUGURATES
THE INDIA-
AFRICA
CONCLAVE**

**"WE HAVE A
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**VIVEK KATJU
SECRETARY, MINISTRY
OF EXTERNAL AFFAIRS**

that have been using some of the east African countries. With sea piracy becoming a major concern, India is now co-operating with African countries around the Gulf of Aden, off the coast of Somalia which has become a fertile ground for sea pirates. "We have a common security interest in the elimination of piracy and we are working towards that, and we will always be a genuine partner in the transformation of Africa," says Vivek Katju, secretary, Ministry of External Affairs. India is now embarking on a police training programme in Namibia, Lesotho, Uganda while defence training is on for Nigeria, Zambia, Botswana and Uganda.

All this stems from a strategic realisation. With 54 votes, African countries can be a big support for India at major international fora such as the UN. Africa is crucial for India in its quest for a support of two third of the UN members for a non-permanent seat in the Security Council for which elections are scheduled later

this year. A recent incident signifies India's changed approach to Africa. Last week, when Congo President Joseph Kabila was on a flight to Seoul, his aircraft developed a snag and had to land in New Delhi on a hot Sunday. The Indian bureaucracy acted with unusual alacrity and within hours a presidential limousine was arranged, the security detail fixed, and the best presidential suite of a five-star hotel was booked. Even minor hiccups like the President not being able to find his passport were taken care of.

Under the new strategy, India will establish 19 institutions to develop human resources and capacities in India besides creating 10 vocational training institutions and five human settlement institutes. To leverage India's soft power, an African cultural festival is also in the works. "We want to turn it into a successful economic engagement for mutual benefit," adds Krishna.

Through training programmes, India is also slip-

ping in a message of good governance to the continent which is mired with political corruption, but there are hurdles on the way. For instance, when the prime minister was slated to visit a prominent African country, the new Indian envoy sent a frantic sos to Delhi seeking guidance. His problem was that the chief of protocol had asked for a bribe to get his credentials done. Finally, the bribe had to be paid out of the envoy's discretionary grant. In several countries many Indian companies have had to pay huge ransoms for kidnappings and as protection money.

New Delhi would need to streamline its Africa strategy with greater focus. For starters, Africa should be on the menu of the senior minister in the foreign office, and not left to a junior minister and there should be more high-level visits. India must ensure that its best and brightest are sent to its missions in Africa to step on the gas in India's new African safari. ■